The End of Aaron

By David James Poissant

GRACE: **(Pg 63-77)** Aaron calls to say we're running out of time,

AARON: Grace, get ten—twenty—gallons of water, eight rolls of duct tape, five pounds of jerky, and a pear. I like pears.

GRACE: And I know we're going to have to do it all over again -- the collecting, the hiding, the waiting to come out. For Aaron, the world is ***always*** ending. It's the third time this year, and it's only July. Probably he's off his meds. *(beat)* Used to be, he'd warn me.

AARON: I'm just going to try. Just for a week or two.

GRACE: When I stopped supporting these experiments, he stopped telling me. Now, I have to guess, which isn't hard given the things that come out of his mouth. The trick is figuring out how long he's been off.

INTRODUCTION

Aaron has suffered from paranoid disorders since childhood. Choosing again to stop taking his medication, he is in the middle of another mental health crisis and has locked himself in the basement of his home to escape the apocalypse he believes is imminent. Can his girlfriend Grace convince save him from himself or will this be . . .

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GRACE: First, he'll feel nothing. Then, week two will hit, and like clockwork, Aaron will start in on that year's fear. It wasn't always the end of the world. For a while, Aaron was afraid to leave the house. Then there was the year of the bees. When he was a child, a bee sting put him in the hospital for two days. Now, everywhere he goes, there's an EpiPen in his pocket. Aaron gets stung, he has less than a minute to plunge the needle into his leg before his throat swells shut. He's only been stung the one time, but twice he's put himself back in the hospital.

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I blame his parents. Not for the depression—I mean, maybe that's their fault. Maybe there's something messed up with their genes. I don't know. I only know that his folks bought into the whole Y2K thing, and Aaron's never been the same since.

Imagine it: You're eight years old, it's New Year's Eve and, instead of watching the ball drop with your parents, you're huddled in the basement, stocked with two years' worth of water, batteries, and green beans, watching your mom cry. Upstairs, Dick Clark counts down. Downstairs, you shut your eyes and wait for the end of the world. Aaron's been waiting ever since.

I've known Aaron most of his life. Truth is, we're twenty and we live with our parents, but that's okay because we have each other, and I've come to believe that each other is enough.

I get everything on Aaron's list. His therapist calls this enabling. I call it love. Home, I pop the trunk. It's got a dozen gallons in it, and I grab the first two. I start up the front steps and almost kick over the jar -- a mason jar fat with amber, lid collared by a yellow bow—a thank-you for ignoring the bees. A while back, the woman next door set up a hive. Aaron's mom petitioned the homeowners association, but the HOA let the lady keep her bees, provided no one got stung, and, in two years, no one has. And now we get honey.

I find Aaron in the basement where he lives. The clothes he has on are the clothes he wore yesterday, and I wonder how long it's been since he slept.

AARON: Come on, come on!

GRACE: He pulls the jar from my hand, and I run back to the car and unload the gallons. I make half a dozen trips up and down the stairs, carrying water, the rolls of tape, the jerky in its five-pound bag. And Aaron stocks his pantry. When I come down the stairs with the last gallon of water Aaron is crying.

AARON: *(screaming and sobbing)* There's no room. There's no more room!

GRACE: I touch his shoulder and he turns, wild-eyed. I hold up the last gallon. *(to Aaron)*

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We can slide it under the bed.

(to audience) How, you're wondering. *How could she love a man who yells, who cries, who makes her carry jugs of water up and down the stairs?* But you're only seeing Aaron unwell. Aaron at his best is better than anyone I've ever known. He's gentle. He's kind. But those are just words. Here's a story: I'm twelve, and, one day, this girl, Mandy Templeton, empties her carton of milk onto my tray and floods my lunch.

MANDY: What're you gonna do, cry about it?

GRACE: We're at that age where, at lunch, boys sit with boys and girls sit with girls, but Aaron hears this; walks over. He taps Mandy Templeton on the shoulder, and, when she turns, he punches her, hard as he can, right in the mouth. Mandy's teeth never looked right afterward, and no one ever messed with Aaron again.

Aaron's always worked that way. And if the trade-off is that, a few weeks a year, he goes cuckoo, then that's a trade-off I'm willing to take. And so I buy the water. I tape the windows. I hunker down with Aaron, and, when I can, I get him to take his medication, knowing that, in a few days, it will kick back in and the man I love will come bubbling up from the ocean floor. He'll break the surface.

Aaron uncaps the honey jar and sticks a finger in. He doesn't offer me any, and I don't ask. *(to Aaron)* So . . . How do you know? *(to audience)* I may as well be asking a toddler how the spaghetti sauce got all over the walls.

AARON: I can feel it.

GRACE: *(to Aaron)* How does it happen? *(to audience)* Aaron turns the TV on. According to the news, there's been a strike in Pakistan. Something to do with American missiles. and the threat of nuclear armament. It's all the evidence Aaron needs.

AARON: If there's a detonation, even a hundred miles away, the fallout alone will keep us underground for ten years.

GRACE: I don't know where Aaron gets his information. Maybe he makes stuff up. Maybe he's trying to scare me, or maybe he believes what he says. Aaron changes the

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channel. More Middle East, more death. The pill bottle is on the dresser. I reach it and uncap it. The next part, I have to be careful.

(to Aaron) How about some medicine, sweetie. *(to audience)* And Aaron knocks the bottle from my hand. The first pill's the hardest, but it's only the beginning. They're antipsychotics, not miracle drugs, and sometimes it's a week before they kick in. Even if I can get this one into him, I have a long road ahead of me. I stand, hands on my hips. Aaron pops the pill.

I brush my teeth over the kitchen sink and when I move back to the bed, Aaron's already asleep. It's almost midnight when he wakes. I tell him to take another pill, and I hear him move to the pantry, hear the honey jar lid come unscrewed followed by a quiet, occasional slurping. *(to Aaron)* Wake me up for the end of the world.

AARON: Don't worry, I will

GRACE: -- no trace of irony, sarcasm, any of it. Maybe it's going to be an easy one. In March, Aaron and I spent an afternoon under the bed. In May, he stayed in the basement, lights off, for a week. But I know that, one of these times, it's not going to be easy. One of these days, no matter what I do, I won't be able to get Aaron back on his meds. *(beat)* The end of the world? It could happen. No one's denying that. But it's the end of Aaron that scares me.

I wake. I turn to put my arm around Aaron, but all I get is pillow. The TV's off. It's still dark outside. I check under the bed. I check the cabinet below the kitchen sink. Aaron doesn't leave the basement, not when he's like this. This is new, and new is scary. There's a sock on his dresser, weirdly out of place. Beneath the sock, I find the pills, chalky, deformed, and I wonder how long each stayed tucked under his tongue before I looked away. This worries me, but not as much as the honey jar -- empty, licked clean.

I tell myself no way could he be where I think he is, but, nights like this, I know better than to underestimate Aaron. I'm up the stairs in seconds, out the door and running

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through the yard. The garage door is up. Gardening tools scatter the driveway like a tornado came. I run faster, into the neighbor's yard. The perimeter is a fence of wood planks too high to climb, but an open gate tells me which way Aaron went. A floodlight flicks on. And there is Aaron. And there is the hive -- a white, wooden box half a coffin in length.

I don't see any bees. No, what I see is Aaron with a rake in his hands in what I can only guess is an attempt to pry open the lid. The rake quivers in his hands. He's got an EpiPen in each leg. I don't know what a jarful of honey and two shots of adrenaline do to a man, but Aaron doesn't look good. He shakes, almost convulsing.

I could call 911. I could run back to the house and pick up the phone, but by then it would be too late. "Aaron," I say, and he jumps. I take a step closer. I don't want to scare him. I don't want him making any sudden moves. From somewhere, a bee rises and swims, lazy, in the air around us.

AARON: I wanted to surprise you.

GRACE: His arms tremble and the rake scrapes the box. *(to Aaron)* Aaron, I want you to put the rake down. Now. *(to audience)* Perhaps, at night, the bees go to bed and don't fly and don't sting. God, I want to believe it. I take another step forward.

AARON: *(shrieking)* Stop!

GRACE: I hold up my hands like a bank teller on the wrong end of a gun.

AARON: *(crying)* I ate all the honey, it's not fair. You didn't get any.

GRACE: I take another step. *(to Aaron)* I'm fine. I don't even like honey all that much. *(to audience)* The rake slaps the hive and rattles the lid. A bee lands on the rake, then lifts back into the sky. Another circles Aaron's head. I'm close. If I lunged, I could grab the rake. I think I could take him down, but what will it mean if I'm wrong.

A hum has started in the box, and that can't be good. *(to Aaron)* Aaron, I want you to put the rake down and come inside. *(to audience)* He's looking right at me, but it's like he can't hear me, can't hear past the grim determination to do the thing he set out to

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do. *(beat)* It's my fault. I shouldn't have slept.

AARON: *(voice garbled and far-away)* Once the bombs fall, there won't be any honey. It's for you . . . All of the honey . . . for you.

GRACE: There are bees in his hair, bees covering the lid of the box. Their wings shine like diamonds in the security lights, and I give up the hope that Aaron hasn't been stung. I leap. I knock Aaron to the ground and pry the rake from his hands. I fling it like a javelin across the yard, far from the hive, and I sit on Aaron's chest, hands pinning his wrists to the lawn.

They say that, with enough adrenaline, you can do anything. You hear stories of mothers lifting cars off their kids. I'm on top of Aaron, but I see too late that the weight of my body is nothing compared to what courses through his veins.

And then I'm in the air. I'm falling and I hit something, hard. The hive comes apart, the buzz turns to roar, and the moon, like magic, goes out of the sky. I hear grunting and turn to see Aaron dragging himself toward me on his elbows, like a soldier passing beneath barbed wire.

I feel a sting, then another. My legs are lightning, and, soon, I can't even look at Aaron, who's no longer crawling, but rolling, a man on fire. I look up and the swarm descends, looking like the end of the world.

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AWARD HISTORY

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